



▲ **HEERAN BALLAI**, 19, VILLAGE AAMRI KALAN
Married at the “grown-up” age—by her village’s standards—of 15 to Nand Ram, her marriage ended in divorce, four years and two children later.
“With two children, I don’t know what my future will be.”

of *gauna*. After an alliance entered into during childhood which holds no meaning for them, boys and girls often grow into individuals who refuse to stand by the hypocrisy of the ritual and prefer to go their own way. Many times, the girls themselves refuse to go with their grooms and walk out of the marriage. While this may provide some reason for cheer to the torchbearers of women’s emancipation it does not help society as the casualness with which marriages are undertaken and broken leads to the breakdown of moral values.

Heeran Ballai of the village Aamri Kalan got married at a “ripe” age of 15, under *atta-satta* to Nand Ram but her exchange failed after four years and two children. She is today worried about her children and her own future but not many like her are worried. Once married and divorced, it becomes easier for them to enter into further alliances. In fact one of the imperatives of a marriage in such communities is that it has to be between two unmarried individuals or two divorcees. Village panchayats frown upon marriages



where just one party is a divorcee and dissolve such relationships. So the earlier one gets to marry, the easier it is for him or her to later enter into any relationship or *naata* of his or her choice. Customs like these often lead to situations where a child, mostly a girl, is married off to a grown-up unmarried man as a mere formality, so that he could divorce her and enter into an informal relationship.

Maitra of village Khara in Bhilwara was married off in a similar fashion and for a similar purpose when she was all of seven to 15-year old Ram Pal. She was given in exchange for a bride for her aging uncle Ram Saroop. For Saroop this marriage was just a ploy to

get rid of his unmarried status. He divorced his wife soon after the wedding but in the process Maitra too was divorced by Ram Pal. “I do not know him,” she says giggling but that does not deter her village folks from referring to her as the one who was left behind. This practice is not without its male victims either. Seventeen-year-old Sanwla Bheel of village Sardarpura was married as a child to a girl seven years elder to him. She spent five days at his home before returning to her parents’ home never to come back. “Now I realise she only married me to get rid of her single status,” says Bheel.

According to Prayas, there are hundreds of instances of people like Gopal Mali who, after getting fed up of

▲ **GOPAL MALI**, 20, VILLAGE DABLA KACHRA
Married as a child, his first wife died when she was seven. Was forced into an informal relationship with a second woman but left her. Entered into a relationship with a divorcee by paying her father Rs 1 lakh.

“I call my third wife *Teen* (three).”

his wife—bought for Rs 11,000 and one-and-half kg of silver—left her to buy a divorcee he fancied for Rs 1 lakh. With rural societies blatantly accepting such norms, it’s little wonder that children are being married while barely out of the cradle, and getting divorced not much later. ■